

Design for Wellbeing – Methods and Strategies for Supporting Psychological Needs in User Experience

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ABSTRACT

While leading technology companies have created “digital wellbeing” initiatives in response to public concern over psychological impacts, these largely focus on changing human behavior (eg. via self-tracking and ‘screen time’ restriction) rather than on changing technology. If respect for human wellbeing is to become a genuine priority with measurable impact, then technology will need to change too. Designers are in a position to lead this change by integrating wellbeing psychology into design practice. This course will equip technology-makers with research-based knowledge and skills for practicing “wellbeing supportive design”, and for improving UX across the board by supporting psychological health.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing**; • **HCI design and evaluation methods**;

KEYWORDS

design methods, evaluation methods, wellbeing, positive computing, positive technologies, design research, behavior change, emotions, user experience;

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1 DURATION

2x80 min sessions

2 BENEFITS

Be the end of this course, participants will be able to:

- **Describe and apply theoretical foundations of wellbeing psychology** – Demonstrate an understanding of, and apply, evidence-based theoretical concepts from the psychology literature that can inform wellbeing supportive technology design.

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- **Employ practical frameworks and tools for wellbeing supportive design** to integrate psychological wellbeing into planning, ideation, analysis, and evaluation of new technologies.
- **Identify real-world examples of wellbeing impact** based on design decisions within technology contexts.
- **Collaboratively generate design strategies for supporting wellbeing** in current and future projects.
- **Use the Wellbeing Design Deck** – Participants will receive a (digital) set of cards including suits for concepts, prompts, and wellbeing determinants (with associated references and tech-based examples) for use during workshop activities and as an ongoing collaboration and reference tool.

3 JUSTIFICATION

Given the digital environment’s influence on psychological health [1], and the increasing public interest in more “humane” [2] products that respect “digital wellbeing”, it is surprising that standard design practice has changed so little in response. For example, commercial digital wellbeing initiatives (i.e., by Google, Apple, and Microsoft) have been created to address public concern, but these largely focus on changing humans rather than on changing software design [3–5]. In order for technologies to better respect psychological needs, designers will need to incorporate wellbeing supportive design knowledge and methods into their practice in ways that are practical and scalable. In this evidence-based workshop we will explore theory, strategies and resources to equip technology-makers with the research-based knowledge and skills necessary to design in ways that better support psychological wellbeing. [6][7]

4 CONTENT

Course content will include basic foundations in wellbeing psychology that can inform wellbeing-supportive technology design in a practical and actionable way. Our approach is centered on technology design that supports the “Basic Psychological Needs” that mediate wellbeing according to four decades of research in Self-Determination Theory conducted across domains (eg. education, health, workplaces) and across cultures and age groups [8]. We explore how these needs can be supported or hindered within the technology context, and present specific real-world examples of design features and methods that can optimize the fulfillment of these needs. The course will also include an introduction to practical frameworks and tools for applying wellbeing concepts to various phases of the design process in order to support wellbeing and other related positive outcomes, such as motivation and meaningful engagement, for a better user experience overall. [9]

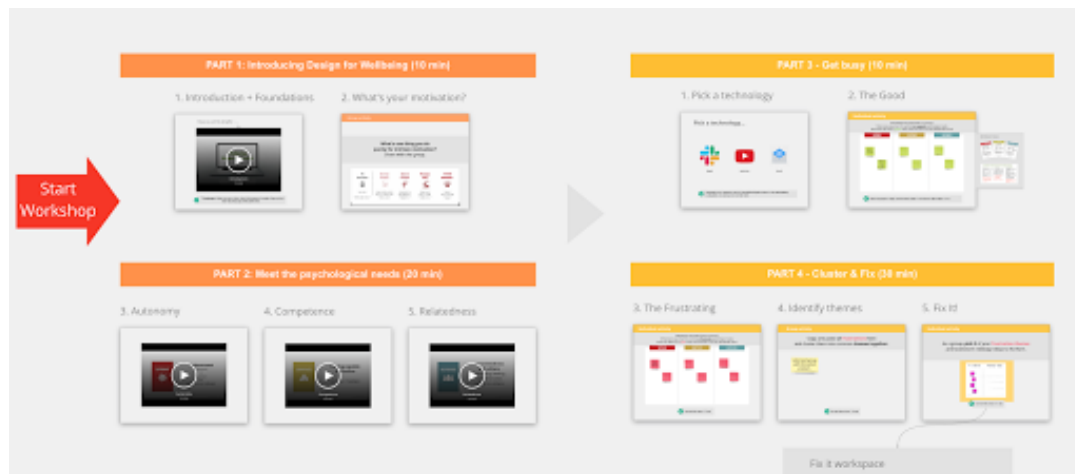


Figure 1: Screenshot of online workshop resources in Miro.

5 INTENDED AUDIENCE

Appropriate for HCI professionals of any background and at any point in their career who are interested in improving user experience through a better understanding of wellbeing psychology and how to apply it to design.

6 PREREQUISITES

None.

7 AUDIENCE SIZE

Min 8, max 100 participants.

8 SCHEDULE

8.1 Part 1 – Introduction to Wellbeing Supportive Design (80 min)

The first 20 minutes will include an introduction to the course and to research foundations in wellbeing psychology that will be drawn on throughout the course. The remaining 60 min will involve small group interaction that will include instructional videos and hands-on activities for accurately understanding 'Basic Psychological Needs' within the technology context and applying this understanding to improve product design. This is a complete rethink of face-to-face activities for optimization in the online world. Participants will engage with activities within small breakout groups (within a Miro board) and instructors will remain accessible for questions at any time via video conferencing and chat. Participants will have received the Wellbeing Design card deck by post in advance, as a tangible reference tool for use during activities and as a reference afterward.

8.2 Part 2 – Make it yours (80 min)

In the first hour, breakout groups will reconvene and continue with collaborative activities, including an opportunity for participants

to consider how wellbeing supportive design strategies could be applied within their own projects or contexts. For the last 20 minutes, the larger group will reconvene for a discussion covering evaluation methods and key takeaways.

9 RESOURCES

Additional background information and references can be found via www.positivecomputing.org.

10 INSTRUCTORS

Dorian Peters is a designer, researcher and author who specialises in design for health and wellbeing, design for learning, and digital ethics in practice. She works at the Leverhulme Centre for the Future of Intelligence at the University of Cambridge and at Imperial College London. Her books include *Interface Design for Learning* (New Riders) and *Positive Computing* (MIT Press), and she is a founding editorial member of the journal, *AI Ethics*.

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